

Soumitra Thorat

Qualitative Researcher

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Summary

Qualitative researcher with 7 years of applied research experience in academic, non-profit, and product environments. Skilled in designing and conducting research studies including semi-structured interviews, usability testing, diary studies, surveys, and concept evaluations to understand user needs and behavior. Experienced analyzing qualitative data and connecting research findings to product decisions. Proven ability to work across disciplines and translate complex research into accessible formats for diverse audiences including academics, practitioners, and community organizations.

Work Experience

PhD Researcher, Work Interaction & Technology Lab, King's College London Oct 2021 to April 2026

- Conducted 30 semi-structured interviews across policy, intermediary, and school stakeholders to understand how users actually adapt and implement technology in complex, real-world settings with uneven resources and competing constraints.
- Collected and analyzed 40 hours of video recordings of naturally occurring classroom interaction; developed systematic coding frameworks to document gaps between intended and actual technology use, employing multimodal analysis integrating video, interview data, and observational notes; identified barriers and workarounds through rigorous visual data analysis.
- Integrated multiple data sources (interviews, ethnographic observation, video analysis) to translate abstract policy directives into concrete, situated user insights; developed narrative-based findings that connect user behavior to broader context and constraints.
- Conducted rigorous qualitative analysis in multilingual context; maintained methodological rigor while ensuring findings remained grounded in actual user behavior rather than user descriptions of behavior.
- Collaborated with education officials and NGO organizations to navigate research access and ethical considerations; translated research findings into accessible formats and language that resonated with non-academic stakeholders including policymakers and practitioners.

Graduate Research Manager, Dept. of Anthropology, George Washington University May 2020 to Jul 2021

- Led multi-method research study on virtual mourning and community engagement during COVID-19, combining interviews, video observation, diary studies, and usability testing across five faith and cultural communities.
- Conducted systematic analysis of how users adapted visual communication platforms (Zoom, Facebook Live, Google Meet) for community rituals.
- Managed end-to-end research process including participant recruitment, informed consent, data collection, analysis, and reporting; coordinated with university partners and community organizations throughout study.
- Translated qualitative research findings into actionable insights; findings demonstrated that user needs around emotional support and community connection supersede feature preferences, informing approaches to informing approaches to community-engaged scholarship with cultural and faith organizations.

Research Consultant, Dept. of Sociology, University of Massachusetts Amherst December 2018 to July 2019

- Conducted ethnographic fieldwork in Galesburg, Illinois examining public-private community redevelopment; conducted 24 interviews and archival research to understand how community narratives shaped (or excluded) different stakeholder perspectives.
- Operationalized analysis at scale: developed the qualitative codebook and intercoder reliability process, improving synthesis speed and decision confidence for partner briefings.
- Translated research findings into actionable policy and implementation briefs; shared findings with both local practitioners and academic audiences through conference presentations.
- Co-authored peer-reviewed research published in Rural Sociology; research recognized with the Research Prize in Public Interest Communications and Outstanding Paper Award from SSSP Poverty, Class, and Inequality Division.

Education

PhD Sociology, King's College London	HCI and workplace studies, qualitative methods, visual data analysis, digital ethnography	2021 to 2026
MA Anthropology, George Washington University	Mixed methods, discourse analysis, HCI	2019 to 2021
BA Anthropology and Sociology, Knox College	Qualitative methods, usability testing	2015 to 2018

Honors and Awards

Sep 2023	Research Prize in Public Interest Communications, University of Florida
Jul 2023	Outstanding Paper Award Co Winner, SSSP Poverty, Class, and Inequality Division
Jul 2019	IRT Fellow, Phillips Academy Andover
Jun 2018	Howell Atwood Award, Knox College